stay.

Bell couldn’t read von Neumann’s original proof himself—it had been published only in German, which Bell didn’t speak. But after reading Born’s description of the proof, Bell “got on with more practical things” than his concerns about the Copenhagen interpretation. He went to work on Britain’s nuclear energy program and put his doubts about quantum physics aside. But, in 1952, Bell “saw the impossible done.” A new paper shattered his short-lived complacency about the problems of the Copenhagen interpretation.

Somehow, despite von Neumann’s proof, a physicist named David Bohm had found another way to understand quantum physics. How? Where had the mighty von Neumann gone wrong, and why hadn’t anyone seen it before Bohm? Bell couldn’t answer these questions without reading von Neumann’s proof. And by the time von Neumann’s book was published in English three years later, life had intervened: Bell had gotten married and gone off to Birmingham to get his PhD in quantum physics. But Bohm’s paper “was never completely out of my mind,” Bell said. “I always knew that it was waiting for me.” Over a decade later, Bell finally returned to it—and made the most profound discovery about the nature of reality since Einstein.